

# Critical Perspectives on Territorial Conflict

Integrating Project Seminar (INTL\_ST 395)

Fall 2026

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Mondays/Wednesdays 2-3:20pm

Annenberg Hall G28

## Course Description

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What distinguishes wars over territory from other types of conflicts? What is the connection between territorial conflict and population transfers between states? How are the lost lands and forced displacement of people remembered and commemorated in the loss-incurring states? In this seminar-style course we will examine these intertwined questions through class discussions and an array of assigned academic articles, book chapters and contemporary and historical case studies of territorial conflicts. We will begin with canonical accounts of territory's indivisibility and unique value, then study the aftermaths of territorial loss for the geographically "shrunk" states. We then turn to population transfers and ethnic cleansing as well as the resulting changes in ethnic composition of states and the unique nature of displaced co-citizens from the lost territories as a new type of national minority. In the second half of the course, we will study the legacies of territorial conflict through scholarship on the inter-generational transmission of trauma, collective memory and path-dependent analysis of territorial conflict in historical perspective. In the final two weeks, we will investigate two case studies of territorial conflict—Finland's loss of Karelia in WWII and Armenia's loss of Nagorno-Karabakh in 2023—and the contemporary resurgence of territorial claims in the US foreign policy and beyond.

## Learning Goals, Assignments and Grading

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### What will you (hopefully) learn in this course?

By the end of the quarter, you should be able to:

- Explain the main concepts in the study of territorial conflicts;
- Compare and evaluate different approaches to the study of territorial loss;
- Analyze and trace the varied impacts and legacies of territorial loss and forced displacement;
- Produce an original research paper formulating an original research question and argument, identifying and properly summarizing relevant literature, evaluating competing answers to your research question, constructing a logically coherent research paper, properly citing your sources and presenting your research to a jury of your peers as well as providing constructive and helpful peer reviews to one another.

## How will I assess your learning and progress in the course?

Your final grade for the course will reflect your engagement in the class meetings, quality and timelines of the ongoing assignments as well as the final research paper. My grading of all assignments will reflect high standards of writing, originality and academic integrity on your part. While you will be challenged in this course, you will also receive the support and help from me to succeed. There is no curve grading in the course and I am more than happy to award all students with the highest grades should they earn them.

### Assignments

I will grade all your assignments using a 100 point scale and then rely on the Northwestern History Department's grading scale as follows:

A(94—100), A-(90—93), B+(87—89), B(84—86), B-(80—83), C(70—79), D(60—69), F(0—60)

### *Class Participation (10%)*

This discussion-based course is highly interactive and requires meaningful participation in every class session. Your participation grade will reflect your attendance and your regular, meaningful, and constructive contributions to class discussion.

| Assessment    | Exemplary (A)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Adequate (B)                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Minimal (C)                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Unacceptable (D/F)                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Participation | Always contributes to class discussion in insightful and meaningful ways, demonstrating clear engagement with course materials. Asks thoughtful, helpful questions. Engages with instructor and fellow classmates with curiosity and respect. | Typically contributes to class discussion in insightful or meaningful ways, often with some indication of engagement with course material. Asks questions. Engages with instructor and fellow classmates with respect. | Infrequently contributes to class discussion in insightful or meaningful ways, with unclear indication of engagement with course materials. Rarely asks questions. Responds to instructor and fellow classmates with respect. | Rarely to never contributes to class discussion in insightful or meaningful ways, with little to no indication of engagement with course material. Fails to treat instructor or classmates with respect. |

*Lead Discussions (10%)* You are required to serve as a lead discussant in our class twice in the quarter. In doing so, you will give a brief (maximum of 10 minutes) oral summary of one of the assigned texts for the week. You should also share one or two questions to start the group discussion. Please sign up for your two lead discussions here: <https://shorturl.at/nNtnt>

*Weekly reading reflections (5% each, total of 35%)*

Every week, you will submit a 2 page long (12pt font, double-spaced) reading reflection on at least *two* of the readings assigned for the week. These reflections should go beyond mere summaries by identifying a theme or a topic that piqued your interest, posing follow-up questions or raising a critique of the arguments presented. Due every Monday at noon via Canvas. Out of the eight weeks, every student can miss one week of choice for this assignment at no penalty. Your two lead discussions shall not take place within the same week.

*Research paper (45% total)*

Your original research papers will be the crown jewel of this course. However, you will have a number of intermediary assignments that will help you build the paper step by step as the quarter progresses. They are as follows:

1. **Territorial conflict proposal and research question** (5%, due Thursday, Oct 1): two page proposal describing the territorial conflict of your choice, your motivation for picking it and outlining a first draft of your research question. No citations required.
2. **Literature review** (5%, due Thursday, Oct 15): A presentation of five academic articles or book chapters beyond the course readings that will form the core of your paper's bibliography. These should be properly formatted and each should be followed by a paragraph or two with the following information: what is the research question of the article? What method do the author use? What is their argument in a nutshell? How does this paper help your own research paper?
3. **Introduction draft** (5%, due Thursday, Oct 29): A two page minimum draft of your paper's introduction which will include your research question, summary of your argument, brief outline of your territorial conflict of choice and a road map for the rest of the paper.
4. **First draft** (5%, due Thursday, November 12): At least 10 pages of your first draft inclusive of the introduction, literature review, case study background and a dab at your argument and evidence. Conclusion is not as critical at this point.
5. **Final paper presentation** (5%, due Monday, November 23): A 10 minute long formal presentation of your paper inclusive of slides.
6. **Peer reviews** (5%, due Wednesday, November 25): A two page written constructive feedback on your colleague's first drafts and in-class presentation. Includes clear and actionable suggestions and advice.
7. **Final paper** (15%, due Monday, December 7): 15-20 pages long (not including bibliography), properly formatted version of your final paper.

## Assignments calendar and grading overview

| Assignment                                | Due date               | Final grade share |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------|
| Class participation                       | Ongoing                | 10%               |
| Two lead discussions                      | TBD                    | 10%               |
| Weekly reading reflections ( $\times 7$ ) | Every Monday at 12pm   | 35%               |
| RP topic proposal and RQ                  | October 1              | 5%                |
| RP literature review                      | October 15             | 5%                |
| RP introduction                           | October 29             | 5%                |
| RP first draft                            | November 12            | 5%                |
| RP presentation                           | November 23 (in-class) | 5%                |
| RP peer review                            | November 25            | 5%                |
| RP final paper                            | December 7             | 15%               |
| <b>Total</b>                              |                        | <b>100%</b>       |

### Late assignment policy

If you fail to submit your assignments by their due date, I will automatically deduct 1 point for each 12-hour period past the assignment's due date. If unforeseen circumstances come up that stand in the way of you submitting your assignment on time, please reach out to me as soon as possible to discuss possible solutions.

## Course Policies

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1. **Office Hours:** My regular in-person student hours will be held on **Wednesdays 12-2pm** in room 3146 in Jacobs Center. Should you want to meet with me outside of these hours, just reach out via email and suggest at least two times that would work for you. These will be most likely held via Zoom as my physical presence on campus will be limited.
2. **Class Attendance and Participation:** Class attendance is mandatory. Each of you gets one pass to miss one class meetings for whatever reason. However, any subsequent missed class will lead to a deduction in your Class Participation grade unless you obtain the appropriate medical note and provide it.

This course is designed as discussion-heavy research seminar, thus student active participation is a core feature of the course. This includes verbal contributions, attentiveness, respect to your classmates and critical engagement with course materials, the instructor, and fellow students. I understand that students are only sometimes comfortable doing so but given the course size a sustained participation from all students is a pre-requisite for the course's overall success.

3. **Readings:** This is an advanced research seminar with somewhat high reading load for each week. You are expected to have read all of the assigned readings ahead of

each class and come prepared to discuss them. All the readings will be shared in appropriate weekly modules on Canvas. Always check the readings calendar at the end of the syllabus to determine what readings are for Mondays and Wednesdays. Typically, Mondays will be heavier on reading assignments and Wednesdays will feature broader discussion of the components of a proper research design. As you read the assigned texts and write your reading reflections, write down any questions that might come to your mind, so that these don't slip away from your memory. Make sure to familiarize yourself with the reading list for this course and set aside ample time in your calendar to go through these every week. Please have the readings ready for our class meetings, either in print or electronic versions as we will often refer specific pages and figures from these.

4. **Screen policy:** This will be a small and discussion-heavy seminar course that will require attention and engagement from every student. If you use an electronic device for managing and annotating the assigned readings, you are allowed to use it as long as the wifi is turned off and the screen is used solely for the purpose of taking notes and pulling up the readings. Please consider going old-school and printing out the articles with hand annotations on the pages, I highly recommend it.
5. **Classroom Conduct Expectations:** Grappling with the topics of territorial conflict, forced displacement and trauma is a complicated and possibly emotional undertaking. While you should never be afraid to disagree with an idea raised during the discussion section, please be mindful that you do so with respect and care for fellow classmates. Regardless of how you feel about another student's perspective, try your best to disagree with ideas and positions not the people who raise them. I genuinely hope that our class section will be a space for constructive and respectful arguments, which will collectively further our understanding and appreciation for the issues discussed.
6. **Academic Integrity and AI Use:** Suspected violations of academic integrity will be reported to the Weinberg College Dean's Office. If a student is found to have committed a violation for any graded assessment, consequences include both disciplinary action from the Dean's Office and a grade of 0 on the relevant assignment. You may *not* use AI for generating any content submitted for this course.
7. **Communication:** The best way to contact me outside of office hours is via email at [matej@u.northwestern.edu](mailto:matej@u.northwestern.edu). I will do my best to respond to each email within 24 hours, but this does not include weekend days and no school days. However, if you have a substantive or assignment-related question, I recommend you come to office hours. If you are unable to make office hours for the week, I will do my best to accommodate that by scheduling a meeting at another time, most likely via Zoom – please email me and suggest two or three days and times that would work for you to schedule these.
8. **Accommodations:** Any students with a mental or physical condition requiring special accommodations should speak with me directly as well as a representative from the Office of Student Assistance and Support Services (AccessibleNU) at 847-467-5530 as soon as possible. Any accommodation-related discussions are strictly confidential.
9. **Title IX Statement:** Northwestern University is committed to fostering an environ-

ment where students are safe and free from sexual misconduct. Confidential resources are available to those who have experienced sexual misconduct. Northwestern faculty and instructors are not confidential resources and are required to report incidents of sexual misconduct, whether discussed in your assignments or in person, to the Office of Equity, which can provide information about resources and options. I strongly encourage students who have experienced sexual misconduct to talk with someone to get support; a good directory of available resources can be found here: [www.northwestern.edu/sexual-misconduct/assistance-support/confidential-support.html](http://www.northwestern.edu/sexual-misconduct/assistance-support/confidential-support.html)

10. **Mental Health:** College is an exciting and formative time, but not one without significant challenges. I know that health, family, work, social life, and other stresses may come to bear on your ability to focus on school, and that this class is not the most important thing in your life. If you are struggling to engage, turn in work, or otherwise participate in this course, please let me know as soon as possible so we can figure out the best way to support your needs. I would also encourage you to familiarize yourself with the services of Northwestern's counseling resources (CAPS).

## Course Reading Schedule

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All readings are available as pdfs on the course Canvas page.

### Week 1: Why Territory? The Stakes of Territorial Conflict

**Keywords:** territorial disputes, interstate rivalry, conflict recurrence, intractability

**Guiding question:** Why is territory a uniquely potent source of interstate conflict, and what makes territorial disputes so difficult to resolve?

*Monday, September 28*

- Diehl, Paul, and Gary Goertz. *Territorial Changes and International Conflict*. London: Routledge, 1992. [Chapter 1: “The Significance of Territory.”]
- Walter, Barbara F. “Explaining the Intractability of Territorial Conflict.” *International Studies Review* 5, no. 4 (2003): 137–53.
- Wiegand, Krista Eileen. *Enduring Territorial Disputes: Strategies of Bargaining, Coercive Diplomacy, and Settlement*. Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2011. [Chapter 1: “The Endurance of Territorial Disputes.”]

*Wednesday, September 30*

- Hensel, Paul R., and Sara McLaughlin Mitchell. “Issue Indivisibility and Territorial Claims.” *GeoJournal* 64 (2005): 275–85.

### Week 2: The Legacies of Territorial Loss

**Keywords:** territorial loss, indivisibility, grievances, conflict recurrence

**Guiding question:** What are the long-term political and social consequences of territorial loss?

*Monday, October 5*

- Quackenbush, Stephen L. “Territorial Issues and Recurrent Conflict.” *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 27, no. 3 (2010): 239–52.
- Shelef, Nadav G. “Unequal Ground: Homelands and Conflict.” *International Organization* 70, no. 1 (2016): 33–63.

*Wednesday, October 7*

- Goddard, Stacie E. “Uncommon Ground: Indivisible Territory and the Politics of Legitimacy.” *International Organization* 60, no. 1 (2006): 35–68.

- Goemans, Hein. “Bounded Communities: Territoriality, Territorial Attachment, and Conflict.” In *Territoriality and Conflict in an Era of Globalization*, edited by Miles Kahler and Barbara F. Walter. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.

### **Week 3: Territorial Conflict, Ethnic Cleansing, and Population Transfer**

**Keywords:** ethnic cleansing, population transfer, displacement

**Guiding question:** How has the reorganization of territory along ethnic lines produced forced displacement and ethnic cleansing of populations?

*Monday, October 12*

- Brubaker, Rogers. “Aftermaths of Empire and the Unmixing of Peoples.” In *Nationalism Reframed: Nationhood and the National Question in the New Europe*, 148–78. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996.
- Mann, Michael. *The Dark Side of Democracy: Explaining Ethnic Cleansing*. Cambridge University Press; 2004. [Chapter 1.]

*Wednesday, October 14*

- O’Leary, Brendan, Ian Lustick, and Thomas M. Callaghy. *Right-Sizing the State: The Politics of Moving Borders*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001. [Introduction]
- O’Leary, Brendan, Ian Lustick, and Thomas M. Callaghy. *Right-Sizing the State: The Politics of Moving Borders*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001. [Chapter 1]

### **Week 4: Nations, Minorities, and the Politics of Displacement**

**Keywords:** nationalism, national minorities, homelands

**Guiding question:** How does the arrival of displaced co-citizens reshape the relationships within the national state?

*Monday, October 19*

- Brubaker, Rogers. “National Minorities, Nationalizing States, and External National Homelands in the New Europe.” In *Nationalism Reframed: Nationhood and the National Question in the New Europe*, 55–76. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996.
- Haklai, Oded, and Neophytos Loizides. *Settlers in Contested Lands: Territorial Disputes and Ethnic Conflicts*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2015. [Chapter 1: “Settlers in Contested Lands.”]

*Wednesday, October 21*

- Shelef, Nadav G. *Homelands: Shifting Borders and Territorial Disputes*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2020. [Chapter 2: “The Shifting Contours of the German Homeland.”]

## Week 5: Mourning, Memory, and Loss

**Keywords:** mourning, collective memory, diasporas

**Guiding question:** What does it mean for a nation to mourn the loss of territory at the individual and collective level?

*Monday, October 26*

- Eng, David, and David Kazanjian, eds. *Loss: The Politics of Mourning*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2002. [Introduction, pp. 1–25.]
- Hirsch, Marianne. “An Interview with Marianne Hirsch.” Columbia University Press, n.d. <https://cup.columbia.edu/author-interviews/hirsch-generation-postmemory/>.
- Olick, Jeffrey K. “Collective Memory: The Two Cultures.” *Sociological Theory* 17, no. 3 (1999): 333–48.

*Wednesday, October 28*

- Lyons, Terrence. “Diasporas and Homeland Conflict.” In *Territoriality and Conflict in an Era of Globalization*, edited by Miles Kahler and Barbara F. Walter, 111–30. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.

## Week 6: Inter-generational Transmission of Trauma

**Keywords:** inter-generational trauma, legacies of violence, nationalist populism

**Guiding question:** How is the trauma of territorial loss and displacement preserved and transformed across generations?

*Monday, November 2*

- Lupu, Noam, and Leonid Peisakhin. “The Legacy of Political Violence across Generations.” *American Journal of Political Science* 61, no. 4 (2017): 836–51.
- Hiers, Wesley, Thomas Soehl, and Andreas Wimmer. “National Trauma and the Fear of Foreigners: How Past Geopolitical Threat Heightens Anti-Immigration Sentiment Today.” *Social Forces* 96, no. 1 (2017): 361–88.

*Wednesday, November 4*

- Cederman, Lars-Erik, Yannick Pengl, Luc Girardin, and Carl Müller-Crepon. “The Future Is History: Restorative Nationalism and Conflict in Post-Napoleonic Europe.” *International Organization* 78, no. 2 (2024): 259–92.
- Carter, Perry J., and Grigore Pop-Eleches. “Territorial Loss and Nationalist Populism.” *Comparative Political Studies* (2025).

## Week 7: Critical Junctures and Path Dependence in Territorial Politics

**Keywords:** critical junctures, path dependence, comparative historical analysis

**Guiding question:** How can the critical juncture framework help us explain why similar experiences of territorial loss produce divergent long-term trajectories?

*Monday, November 9*

- Collier, David, and Gerardo Munck. “Research on Critical Junctures: Template, Examples, Best Practices.” *Critical Juncture Project*, 2018. <https://www.critical-juncture.net/>.
- Capoccia, Giovanni, and R. Daniel Kelemen. “The Study of Critical Junctures: Theory, Narrative, and Counterfactuals in Historical Institutionalism.” *World Politics* 59, no. 3 (2007): 341–69.
- Mylonas, Harris. “The International Politics of Assimilation, Accommodation, and Exclusion.” In *The Politics of Nation-Building: Making Co-Nationals, Refugees, and Minorities*, 17–50. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013.

*Wednesday, November 11*

- Wimmer, Andreas. “Layered Legacies: How Multiple Histories Shaped the Attitudes of Contemporary Europeans.” *Sociological Science* 10 (2023): 1–46.

## Week 8: Case Studies in Territorial Mourning — Karelia and Nagorno-Karabakh

**Keywords:** Karelia, Nagorno-Karabakh, territorial phantom pains, diaspora identity

**Guiding question:** How do the Finnish and Armenian experiences of territorial loss and displacement illuminate different pathways of territorial mourning?

*Monday, November 16*

- Alasuutari, Pertti, and Maarit Alasuutari. “Narration and Ritual Formation of Diasporic Identity: The Case of Second Generation Karelian Evacuees.” *Identities* 16, no. 3 (2009): 321–45.
- Łukianow, Małgorzata, and Chloe Wells. “Territorial Phantom Pains: Third-Generation Postmemories of Territorial Changes.” *Memory Studies* 17, no. 2 (2024): 177–92.

*Wednesday, November 18*

- International Crisis Group. “Armenia Struggles to Cope with Exodus from Nagorno-Karabakh.” March 4, 2024. <https://www.crisisgroup.org/europe-central-asia/armenian-azerbaijani-conflict-armenia/armenia-struggles-cope-exodus-nagorno-karabakh>.

- Chernobrov, Dmitry, and Leila Wilmers. “Diaspora Identity and a New Generation: Armenian Diaspora Youth on the Genocide and the Karabakh War.” *Nationalities Papers* 48, no. 5 (2020): 915–30.

## **Week 9: Contemporary Territorial Conflicts and Policy Implications**

**Keywords:** conquest, territorial norms, climate displacement, US expansionism,

**Guiding question:** What do contemporary cases of territorial ambition and climate-induced displacement tell us about the future of territorial conflicts?

*Wednesday, November 25*

- Fazal, Tanisha M. “Conquest Is Back.” *Foreign Affairs*, March 21, 2025.
- “Why Trump’s Greenland, Canada, Panama Comments Are Dangerous.” *Foreign Policy*, January 14, 2025. <https://foreignpolicy.com/2025/01/14/trump-us-president-greenland-canada-panama-expansionism-history/>.
- Neef, Katja Phutaraksa. “The Experience of Loss and Grief in Forced Displacement and Planned Relocation in the Pacific.” *Sites* 19, no. 1 (2022): 82–93.